



BEFORE

In the wake of Ulysses S. Grant's masterly disengagement from the North Anna River ([see Maneuvering toward Richmond](#)), both armies continued their running battle, sparring southeastward.

HAW'S SHOP

General Robert E. Lee took up a strong position on the south bank of **Totopotomoy Creek**, with Pamunkey River to the north and Chickahominy River to the south. On May 28 he sent a cavalry **reconnaissance eastward** to test Grant's position. His men met Union horsemen near **Haw's Shop**, a local forge, and the resulting five-hour battle became one of the **bloodiest cavalry engagements** of the entire war.

BETHESDA CHURCH

On May 30 Grant pushed across Totopotomoy Creek, seeking Lee's right flank. The infantry of both armies **clashed at Bethesda Church**. Farther east, cavalry units fought at Old Church, but the Confederate horsemen fell back on a crossroads called **Cold Harbor**. Grant, believing Lee's lines unbreakable, was also casting an eye on Cold Harbor. A **major battle** was shaping up.

The dusty little hamlet of Cold Harbor sat in country so flat that only ravines cut by sluggish streams provided relief. Five roads radiated from the settlement like wheel spokes, including two to the southwest, which led over bridges across the Chickahominy River to Richmond, 8 miles (13km) away.

On June 1, 1864, this hamlet saw cavalry units fighting for its possession. As the afternoon wore on, infantry began arriving. Troopers in blue held the crossroads as Lee's divisions began approaching from the north. Grant's soldiers were marching along a parallel track, but some of them had become lost and were slow coming up. Although Lee's line stretched nearly 7 miles (11km), from Totopotomoy Creek in the north to the banks of the Chickahominy, the leading elements managed to block the road to Richmond. Lee's veterans dug in where they halted. Grant's men aligned opposite, and as evening fell the Union commander hurled them at the Southern line. "Aim low and aim well," one Confederate general advised his troops. For a few minutes, the Confederate lines blazed with rifle fire. Everywhere the Yankees fell back, except where one division nearly opened a breach, using a ravine for cover. This near-breakthrough impressed Grant, who thought one big push might divide the Army of Northern Virginia.